

Mumbai Parliament Of Religions Highlights Role Of Faith In Addressing Social Challenges

The meet was organised by the Inter-Religious Solidarity Council (IRSC), The Centre for the Study of Society and Secularism, and The Baha'i Centre.

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The relevance of religion in addressing current social challenges: this was the subject of the second edition of the Mumbai Parliament of Religions held at The Baha'i Centre on Saturday.

The meet was organised by the Inter-Religious Solidarity Council (IRSC), The Centre for the Study of Society and Secularism, and The Baha'i Centre. The panel included Gandhian scholar and author Rajni Bakshi; educationist Dr Surinder Kaur; Prabhu Govind Das from the Hare Krishna religious spiritual movement; Baha'i Tahirih Mahija; spiritual author and guide Roshani Shenazz; Islamic scholar Mufti Yahya; Catholic priest Father Gilbert De'lima; and Swami Dayadipananda, a monk from the Ramakrishna Mission. Urmi Chanda from IRSC moderated the meeting, which was attended by an audience of around 150 people, including students.

Religion as a Moral Compass

Das, convenor of the IRSC, said in his opening remarks that religion has consistently acted as a moral compass and spiritual anchor, guiding humanity through turbulent times. He emphasised that genuine religion is rooted in service, compassion, equality, and truth, not exclusion or oppression. Das said that the misuse or misunderstanding of religion leads to division, but when it is practiced at its core, religion has the potential to heal, unite, and transform society.

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Faith and Social Equity

“Can faith traditions respond meaningfully to gender equality, support the rights and dignity of LGBTQIA+ communities, and help break barriers of caste and social inequality?,” asked Das, while urging participants not to debate superiority, but to listen, learn, and build together for social good.

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Panelists Highlight Unity and Compassion

Bakshi stressed the importance of embracing the otherness of others. Mahija spoke on crisis and victory, illustrating humanity’s progress toward unity and

equality through spiritual renewal. Kaur spoke about the challenges faced by women in conflict zones. De'lima cited communal conflicts in Nagaland and Manipur and said that religion can be used as a force for unity.

Dayadipananda said that divinity exists within all of us, noting that in every religion there are those who may not believe in divine power but hold it through their experiences. Shenazz spoke about the Zoroastrian principles of good thoughts, good words, and good deeds. Yahya gave an Islamic perspective on family and relationships. Radhika Sood Nayak, singer and vocalist, gave the event a celebratory atmosphere with her soulful songs.

